

H-2B Application Toolkit

Your free starter kit for seasonal work in the U.S. from Jamaica

What is the H-2B visa?

H-2B is a U.S. visa for **temporary, seasonal, non-farm work**. You do **not** need to be a student. Typical jobs include hotels and resorts, housekeeping, kitchens, landscaping, amusement parks, and seafood and meat processing.

A U.S. employer gets approval to hire foreign workers because it cannot find enough U.S. workers. The employer must offer work for at least three-fourths of the contract period, and must pay or reimburse the worker's visa fee and certain travel costs. After the employer's petition is approved, the worker attends a visa interview at the U.S. Embassy in Kingston.

The yearly limit

The U.S. limits H-2B visas to **66,000 per year**, and demand usually beats the limit. Employers file early for spring jobs, so the time to get organised is **before the season opens**. No agency can guarantee you a visa.

The 6 steps

1

Get your documents ready

Passport, TRN, NIS number, birth certificate and more (see page 2).

2

Check the agency is licensed

Confirm it with the Ministry of Labour before paying or sending documents (see page 4).

3

Call 2 to 3 agencies

Use the call script and 8 questions. Log every call.

4

Apply and interview with the agency

Agencies screen candidates and put them forward to U.S. employers.

5

The employer applies for approval

This takes months, and approval is not guaranteed.

6

Visa interview and travel

Once the petition is approved, attend the interview at the U.S. Embassy in Kingston.

Also worth trying: the Ministry's own programme. The Ministry of Labour and Social Security runs its own Overseas Employment Programme, and the Minister has said there is **no fee at any stage** of the Ministry's recruitment or placement. Ask your Member of Parliament's constituency office, or the Ministry, how selection works in your area.

Document checklist

Ask each agency for its exact list, but expect to need most of these. Tick them off as you go.

☐	Valid passport (check the expiry date now)
☐	Taxpayer Registration Number (TRN)
☐	National Insurance Scheme (NIS) number
☐	Birth certificate and valid photo ID
☐	Police record (ask the agency who it must be addressed to before you apply)
☐	Passport-sized photos
☐	Short résumé with past jobs and dates
☐	Names and phone numbers of work references
☐	Contact details for a relative or friend (in case you cannot be reached)

Don't order your police record too early. A Jamaican police record is issued for one named recipient and cannot be reused for another. Find out exactly who it should be addressed to before you pay for one.

Tip: keep clear photos or scans on your phone, but do **not** send passport copies to anyone until you have confirmed they are licensed.

What to say when you call

"Good morning. My name is _____. I am calling about H-2B work in the U.S. for the coming season. Are you taking applications, and how do I get an appointment or interview?"

8 questions to ask every agency

- 1 Is your Ministry licence current, and what is the licence number?
- 2 Which U.S. employers and industries do you work with?
- 3 What jobs, pay rates, locations and start dates are available?
- 4 What are your requirements (age, experience, documents)?
- 5 What fees, if any, do I pay, and when? Will I get a receipt?
- 6 Will I get a written contract or job offer before I pay or travel?
- 7 How long does the process take, and how will you keep me updated?
- 8 How many Jamaicans did you place last season?

Anyone can say yes to everything. Trust the written paperwork, not the promises. Call two or three agencies and compare.

Call log

Write down every call: the date, who you spoke to, what they said, and when to follow up. Follow up politely if you hear nothing for a week.

Date	Agency and phone	Person spoke to	What they said (jobs, fees, contract)	Follow up on

Agency scorecard

After your calls, compare the agencies side by side. Write Yes or No in each box, then choose the one with the most Yes answers.

Check	Agency 1	Agency 2	Agency 3
The Ministry confirmed the licence is current			
Named the U.S. employer and the job			
Offers a written contract or job offer			
Clear about any fees, and gives receipts			
Did not pressure me to pay today			
Answered my questions and called back			

Print this page as many times as you need. Keep your receipts and any written contract in one folder.

Scam red-flag card

The U.S. Embassy in Kingston has warned that unregistered recruiters have a history of charging illegal fees. Walk away if you see any of these.

- X Promises a guaranteed visa or a paid "fast-track"**
- X Asks for cash with no receipt**
- X Asks you to pay by WhatsApp or mobile money**
- X No written contract or job offer**
- X Cannot give a licence number, or the Ministry cannot confirm it**
- X Pressures you to pay today**
- X Offers jobs only on TikTok, Instagram or Facebook, with no named employer**
- X Asks for your passport before anything has been checked**

About fees. Under U.S. rules, H-2B employers and their recruiters may not charge workers a recruitment or placement fee. If an agency asks you for any payment, ask the Ministry's Employment Agencies Unit whether that fee is allowed **before you pay**, and always get a receipt.

The Embassy checks your recruiter. You must name your recruiting agency on your visa application. If it is not registered with the Ministry or on the U.S. Department of Labor's list, the application is rejected. Be honest on every form: fraud can make you permanently ineligible for a U.S. visa.

Key contacts

Ministry of Labour and Social Security Employment Agencies Unit	Check that an agency is licensed, and report one that is not. 1F North Street, Kingston Phone: 876-676-5806 or 876-676-5748 · WhatsApp: 876-553-5457 Email: employmentagencyunitja@mlss.gov.jm List of approved agencies: www.mlss.gov.jm
Ministry's Overseas Employment Programme	The Ministry's own programme (no fee): www.mlss.gov.jm
U.S. Department of Labor recruiter list	A second place to check a recruiter: www.dol.gov/agencies/eta/foreign-labor/recruiter-list Visa interview instructions: jm.usembassy.gov

Updated October 2026. The Ministry's list of approved agencies changes monthly, so always check the latest version. Licences, fees, dates and requirements change: confirm current details with the Ministry, the agency and the U.S. Embassy in Kingston.

Need your documents ready in time? Laura Clarke Administrative Services helps with passports, police records, birth certificates, and TRN and NIS application packages. We do not recruit or place workers. WhatsApp +1 (876) 561-2614 · documenthelpja.com